

Goals galore: Newly promoted Ipswich Town was at the receiving end of Erling Haaland (left) and Mohamed Salah (below). **Right:** Chelsea's Joao Felix (14) set things rolling with a goal against Wolverhampton Wanderers.

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enough, the return of Ilkay Gundogan (after a one-year stint with Barcelona) amplified the atmosphere at the Etihad, as several fans held banners reading, 'Welcome home, Gundo'.

For Arsenal, the priority this season is to avoid creating another 'if only' scenario after coming close to challenging City for the title but stumbling at the final hurdles in recent seasons. Mikel Arteta and his men have at least started on the right foot, winning 2-0 against Wolves in their opening fixture and following it up with a hard-fought victory against Aston Villa by the same margin. Arteta has stressed the importance of multiple players contributing to the scoreline, rather than relying on a single player, and the Spaniard will be pleased to see four different scorers in two matches — Kai Havertz, Bukayo Saka, Leandro Trossard, and Thomas Partey.

Backed by INEOS and a successful transfer window, Erik Ten Hag will have limited scope for excuses, especially after being reprieved from a potential sacking following the FA Cup win against Man City. Before the Red Devils' season-opener against Fulham, the Dutch manager admitted that his team wasn't ready for the new season, and this was evident as his men struggled to secure a 1-0 win against Fulham, courtesy of a late goal by new arrival Joshua Zirkzee. However, United failed to maintain momentum, falling to its recent bogey team — Brighton and Hove Albion, the latter notching up a 2-1 win.

Mohamed Salah surprised many with his new look ahead of the season. But on the pitch, things were the same, as the Egyptian was at his lethal best. In Liverpool's season opener against Ipswich, Salah set up Diogo Jota for the opener before

getting on the scoresheet himself. With that goal, the Egyptian entered the record books as the all-time top scorer on Premier League opening days with nine goals. Salah found the net again in the Reds' next match against Brentford, while Jota set up Luis Diaz to guide Liverpool to a 2-0 win.

Chelsea has been under the spotlight for its active summer transfer window, signing 11 players, and receiving considerable criticism for its inflated squad size of 42 first-team players. However, manager Enzo Maresca has brushed off claims of an inflated squad, highlighting the importance of every player. The Blues did not have the easiest start, facing City in its campaign opener. A 2-0 loss against City didn't raise eyebrows, but the Blues came back in prime fashion, beating Wolverhampton Wanderers 6-2 in the following game week. Noni Madueke starred with an excellent hat-trick, while Cole Palmer exuded his usual class with three assists and a goal. Nicolas Jackson also got on the scoresheet, while Joao Felix marked his permanent move to London with an excellent finish for Chelsea's sixth.

Tottenham Hotspur delivered a dominant display after a frustrating 1-1 draw against Leicester in its opener, drubbing Everton 4-0, with Son Heung-Min grabbing a brace.

Newcastle United, now backed by cash-rich Saudi Arabian owners,

started with a 1-0 win against the promoted Southampton but was held to a 1-1 draw against Bournemouth.

After the first two rounds of fixtures, the top four teams have six points each. However, courtesy of goal difference, City sits at the top, followed by Brighton, Arsenal, and Liverpool in second, third, and fourth, respectively. Tottenham and Newcastle are fifth and sixth, while Man United languishes in the bottom half of the table in 11th.

Among promoted teams, only Leicester City has a point on the board, while Ipswich and Southampton are yet to open their accounts.

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